FREE CHECKLIST

Five questions to ask any laboratory supplier

Judging a research-compound supplier does not need a laboratory — it needs the right five questions, asked before you order. How quickly and clearly a supplier answers tells you almost as much as the answers themselves.

1. **Who tested this batch?**
   Good answer: a named, independent laboratory you can look up. Weak answer: “our lab”, “third-party tested” with no name, or the manufacturer’s own paperwork only.

2. **Is the certificate for the exact lot you will send me?**
   Good answer: yes — the lot number on the certificate matches the label, and you can see it before you pay. Weak answer: one sample certificate for the product, whatever the batch.

3. **Does it include an identity result, not just purity?**
   Good answer: mass spectrometry with observed and expected mass, plus HPLC purity. Weak answer: a purity percentage alone. Purity says how clean a sample is, not which molecule it is.

4. **How is the order stored, packed and shipped?**
   Good answer: cold storage before dispatch, insulated packaging, fast courier, clear handling notes. Weak answer: vague, or “it’s fine at room temperature” with no detail.

5. **How do you present what you sell?**
   Good answer: clearly as laboratory material, with documentation and handling information. Warning sign: marketing that describes effects on people, offers dosing advice, or uses before-and-after claims. That is a regulatory problem for the seller and a reliability signal for you.

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COPY, PASTE, SEND

The message

Send this to any supplier you are considering. A good one replies within a working day and answers every point.

Hello — before I place an order, could you tell me:

1. Which laboratory tested the batch you would send me, and is it independent of you?
2. Is the certificate for that exact lot, and can I see it before I pay?
3. Does it include an identity result by mass spectrometry, as well as HPLC purity?
4. How is the order stored before dispatch, and how is it packed and kept cool in transit?
5. What documentation and handling information is included with the order?

Thank you.

Score the reply

Reply	What it suggests
All five answered, laboratory named, lot certificate shared	A supplier with nothing to hide. A strong start.
Answered, but the certificate is generic	Ask specifically for your lot. If it never arrives, treat the certificate as decoration.
Vague, slow, or answers different questions	Common with resellers who do not hold their own documentation.
Offers advice on use in people, or dosing	Walk away. That is not a laboratory supplier.

Before you pay — quick checklist

- [ ] Laboratory named and independently verifiable.
- [ ] Certificate lot number will match the label.
- [ ] Identity (mass spectrometry) and purity (HPLC) both reported.
- [ ] Cold storage and insulated, tracked shipping described.
- [ ] Sold and documented as laboratory material only.

Want to go deeper? Our free guide How to read a certificate of analysis explains every line of a certificate: pepcolab.com/learn/coa-guide

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